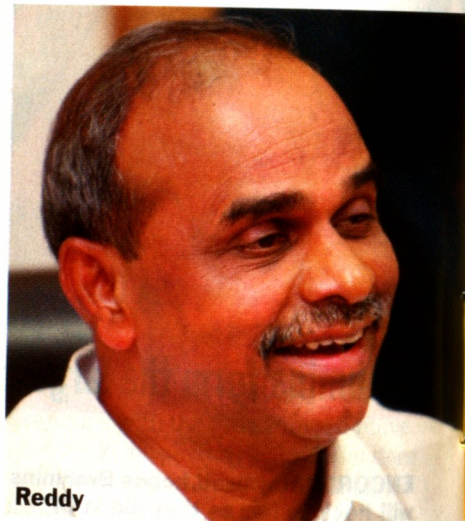


FUTURE

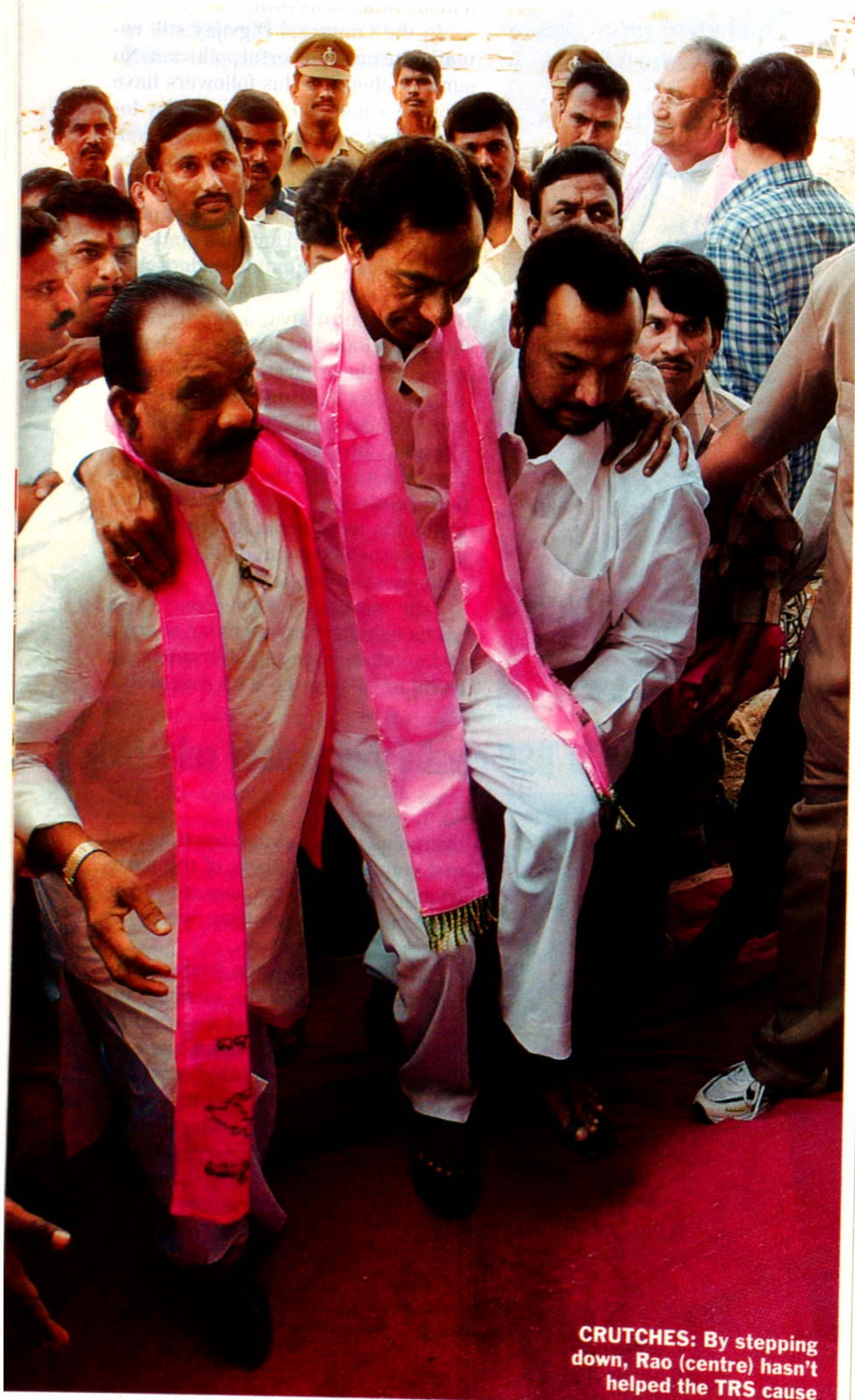
■ By Amarnath K. Menon

It was a gamble that backfired. In March, the Telangana Rashtra Samiti (TRS) chief K. Chandrashekara Rao asked all party MPs and MLAs to quit their seats, forcing by-elections, which he was certain his party would win and thus prove that the seven-year-old TRS and its separate statehood slogan still enjoyed popular backing. But the drubbing the party got was a slap on its face. Its miscalculation and bravado led to the TRS strength declining from 26 to just seven MLAs and two MPs instead of four in 2004.



Reddy

Desertions are likely even as the party think-tank discovers factors responsible for its poor show include its failure to convey to the electorate the need for the by-elections and Rao's own irascible conduct. His failure to take up a single public issue over the years in the belief that statehood for TRS was the panacea for all problems has cost the party dear. Worse still, Rao, who had won the Karimnagar Lok Sabha seat with a huge margin in 2004 and again by a wide margin of over two lakh votes in the by-election he forced in 2006, managed to win this time by a meagre 15,675 votes. In as many as eight of the 16 Assembly constituencies the erosion of support was so high that TRS finished behind the Congress or TDP and even for-



CRUTCHES: By stepping down, Rao (centre) hasn't helped the TRS cause

Photographs by A. PRABHAKAR RAO